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A BRIEF HISTORY OF THE

49TH FIGHTER GROUP

This very brief history of the 49th Fighter Group was compiled by Private Louis T. Scott, 20820502, under the direction of Captain Louis T. Iglehart. The source of material was the complete edition of the Group History on file at the 49th Fighter Group Headquarters. The period covered is from the date of activation, 16 January 1941, to 1 July 1945.

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DATE *15 July 45*

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RESTRICTEDA BRIEF HISTORY OF THE 49TH FIGHTER GROUP

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The 49th Fighter Group, comprising Headquarters and Headquarters Squadron, 7th, 8th and 9th Pursuit Squadrons, was activated at Selfridge Field, Michigan, 16 January 1941. Nucleus of the Group was formed of officers and men of the 31st Pursuit Group and were for the most part from the southeastern states. The first commanding officer of the new pursuit group was Major Glenn L. Davasher but because he was hospitalized for the greater part of the time, he never actively assumed command. Until Major Davasher was relieved of duty, Captain John F. Egan served as commanding officer. On 2 May Major George McCoy Jr. was assigned and took command of the group.

The first of many moves for the new organization came in May, 1941 when the group moved via motor convoy to Morrison Field, West Palm Beach, Florida. Following this, a program was instituted to complete the training of the group. Pilots of the group participated in the Louisiana maneuvers in the fall of 1941 and various schools in all parts of the States served to teach personnel of the group. On November 15 another squadron was added to the 49th when the 49th Interceptor Control Squadron was activated. Personnel of the three pursuit squadrons and casualties from Morrison Field were utilized for that purpose.

The beginning of the war started a splurge of rumors regarding the part this group would play in the conflict with the majority of guessers placing the 49th either in Panama or South America. Major Paul B. Wurtsmith, who was assigned to the group in late November, assumed command on 11 December 1941. Rumors of an imminent move became fact on December 25th when all personnel were informed that the group would soon depart from Morrison Field for the west coast. The move

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began on 2 January 1942 when advance etails left for San Francisco. The remainder of the Group entrained on the 4th and arrived in San Francisco on the 8th.

Until the transport which was to carry the 49ers off to the wars, the U.S.A.T. MARIPOSA, was loaded, personnel were quartered in the huge livestock pavilion in the southern part of San Francisco. Loading was completed during the morning of 12 January and the ship sailed at 1630 that afternoon for an as yet undisclosed destination, accompanied by the U.S.A.T. COOLIDGE, the S.S. MONROE and the light cruiser, the U.S.S. PHOENIX. The group celebrated its first birthday, 16 January 1942 aboard the MARIPOSA.

On the morning of 1 February, after nineteen days at sea, personnel aboard the MARIPOSA had their first glimpse of land since leaving San Francisco. Off the starboard side a few miles distant were the stony cliffs and hills of Wilson Promitory at the southeastern tip of Australia. Escorted by the Australian cruiser, H.M.A.S. ADELAIDE, the MARIPOSA dropped anchor in Melbourne harbor, Australia, at 1800 on 1 February. Thus the 49ers were the first Air Corps pursuit group to arrive abroad since the start of World War II.

Personnel were quartered in Royal Park, Melbourne, and Camp Darby, Bacchus Marsh, 30 miles from Melbourne. Later the 9th Squadron was transferred to Williamstown, New South Wales, so the pilots could train in the P-40E's which had been brought across in the S.S. MONROE. R.A.A.F. facilities were loaned by the Australian government for this purpose. Still later in February Headquarters & Headquarters Squadron, 7th, & 8th Pursuit Squadrons left Camp Darby, and the Interceptor Control Squadron quitted Royal Park, all bound for Bankstown, N.S.W., a suburb of Sydney. While there, on February 19, Major Paul B. Wurtsmith was notified of his promotion to Lieutenant Colonel effective 5 December 1941.

The time spent at Bankstown was devoted to training of the group---until first blood was drawn by the 49ers on 14 March. On that day a flight of the 7th Squadron, led by Captain Robert L. Morrissey engaged a Jap bombing raid over Horn Island,

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northeastern Australia. On that occasion 2nd Lieut. A. T. House, Jr., wingman for Captain Morrissey, shot down two of the enemy fighter planes, the second of which he bagged in a fete heralded in the world-wide press and radio. After shooting down the first plane, Lieut. House engaged the second, firing a short burst. Then his guns jammed! Undaunted, Lieut. House maneuvered his P-40E over the Zero, and suddenly dipped his right wing tip into the Jap's cockpit. The Zero was almost ripped in two and went plummeting to earth. With three feet of his right wing torn away Lieut. House had difficulty keeping his plane from rolling but managed a safe landing at his base.

The 9th Squadron was again the first unit to move, leaving on 16 March for their new operational base at Darwin, Northern Territory. Their mission was a defense of this northwesternmost Australian town, a regular target for Japanese bombers and a probable gateway into Australia for an invading Japanese Army. Pilots made the trip via air while ground personnel went via standard and narrow gauge railroads, and finished it in a motor convoy. On March 17 verbal orders were issued attaching to the 49th Pursuit Group a number of officers who had fought the enemy in the Philippines and Java, and who had finally reached Australia. Among them were Captain Boyd "Buzz" Wagner, Captain Walter L. Coss, Captain Allison W. Strauss, and 2nd Lieut. R. B. Dockstader. Their knowledge of Japanese tricks was used in the training of the 49ers.

The remainder of the group left for Darwin early in April. There, until the Group was relieved by the R.A.A.F. and departed for New Guinea late in September, numerous clashes with enemy bombers and escorting fighters was the order of the day. The Group acquired an excellent record for its defense of Port Darwin and the destruction of enemy attackers. It ^{was} emassed a number of awards for its pilots, including a unit citation for the Group as a whole. Changes in personnel were also made,

when some men left for the hospital, or flying personnel were sent home and their replacements arrived. The organizational structure was changed somewhat when, on 31 August 1942, orders were issued inactivating Headquarters & Headquarters Squadron, sending many of the men to the various Fighter (a new name adopted by the War Department for pursuit units) Squadrons and the Fighter Control Squadron.

While at Darwin numerous odd incidents occurred and one of the most interesting was the experience of 2nd Lieut. Robert H. Vaught of the 9th Squadron, bitten by a snake while on a flight in his P-40. Lieut. Vaught took off in the morning from Livingstone Field (named for 2nd Lieut. John D. Livingstone, Jr., 9th Squadron, who was killed in April) on a local hop, and well after getting into the air he discovered a three-foot snake coiled between his legs and ready to strike. In an attempt to get rid of his unwelcome passenger, Lieut. Vaught made a sudden right bank. But this brought his left foot back, and the snake struck. With a quick lunge, Lieut. Vaught seized the snake behind the head and tossed it out, sans parachute. Lieut. Vaught then landed at what proved to be an abandoned ranch where he spent the night. The next morning he applied a splint to the leg and took off for Livingstone Field where he was forced to crash-land. He suffered no further injury but was rushed to the hospital for treatment to his leg.

Another incident is given---without names. Men of Group Headquarters recalled the day months before when they, bound for foreign service, had boarded the train at West Palm Beach, Florida. Standing in the crowd watching them depart was a certain "wise guy" who waved jauntily and shouted: "So long, suckers!" On 20 July, amid the heat and dust and flies of the Northern Territory, the "wise guy" was attached and assigned to the squadron of "suckers." These and many other incidents would long prove a source of conversation for the boys who could---and certainly would---tell how rough life was at Darwin.

On 9 October 1942 the men of Headquarters, 7th and 8th Fighter Squadrons

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reached their new base in New Guinea after a ten-day voyage in the S.S. SEAWITCH, while the 9th Squadron arrived aboard the S.S. VAN HEUTSZ a short while later. The 49th Fighter Control Squadron was sent to New Guinea via ROCKHAMPTON, Australia. A camp was pitched overlooking Kila Strip, Port Moresby, quite close to the Laloki River. Immediately after arriving there orders were issued placing an (at that time) unknown pilot, 2nd Lieut. Richard I. Bong, assigned to the 9th Squadron but still at Amberley Field, Brisbane, on temporary duty at Garbutt Field, Townsville, to ferry planes. Other orders were issued reestablishing the 17th Fighter Squadron (Provisional) famed for its exploits over Bataan and in Java and Bali, as a unit of the 49th Fighter Group. Many of the 49ers who had been graduates of the 17th and had fought their way backwards from Manila to Darwin were happy to see an attempt to organize the old outfit.

On 11 November 1942 Lieut. Colonel Donald R. Hutchinson was appointed to command the group and Colonel Wurtsmith became commanding officer of V Fighter Command. In New Guinea a new type of combat began for members of the 49th. No longer was their work all interception. The P-40's were utilized as dive bombers and pilots became quite proficient at this, receiving a number of commendations from both American and Australian officers. Early in January an event occurred which promised an increase in the group score at an early date. On the 4th the 9th Squadron received its first P-38 "Lightnings." A number of pilots, including Lieut. Bong, were recalled from their "loan" to the 35th Fighter Group and training in the twin-engine jobs began. Soon these planes and their pilots were engaged in escort and cover missions, and searching out enemy shipping in the Bismarck Sea.

Another move was impending, this time across the "Hump" to Dobodura. The advance echelon included the group commander, Lieut. Colonel Robert L. Morrissey, who assumed command 30 January when Colonel Hutchinson was transferred to V Fighter Command. The camp area at Dobodura proved to be a better set-up than the boys had

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in the vicinity of Port Moresby. The Fighter Control Squadron rejoined the Group but for a short time only, for orders were promulgated by the War Department making this squadron a separate unit. Air raids were more constant and the group suffered a number of casualties because of them. The Dobodura base was much closer to the enemy at Lae and Salamague than Port Moresby, and many air attacks were carried out over these bases. Many escort missions were also flown to New Britain, cumulating in the 12 October mass attack on Rabaul with B-17's, B-24's, B-25's, B-26's, P-38's, P-47's and Beaufighters. While at Dobodura the group brought the score to a total of 209 enemy aircraft destroyed in the air. This however, wasn't accomplished without casualties on our side. Various Allied cemeteries on both sides of the "Hump" will attest to that, and a number of pilots were lost, either in the jungle or in the water; their bodies never recovered. A number of pilots joined the "49er Catapiller Club", bailing out over both Allied and enemy-held jungle country. The various stories of their walk-backs are very interesting but too lengthy for insert in a brief history such as this. A sample story is that of Lieut. Paul Yeager, 9th Squadron, who hit the silk on 2 June. While returning from a scramble with other P-38's, Lieut. Yeager's plane caught fire and he had to bail out. He landed in the tree tops overlooking a high cliff about three miles southwest of Middle Embi Lake. Eventually he was rescued by a party of group officers, escorted by an Aussie infantry patrol and supplied by Piper Cub drop missions. Other pilots owed their rescue to the New Guinea natives who almost solidly remained pro-Allied despite both threats and offers of reward by the Japanese.

The matter of morale of the group at Dobodura was somewhat complicated. Many of the men had served overseas for a long period of time and no plan as yet had been presented, offering them the chance of return to the States. First replacements for enlisted personnel and ground officers arrived in April, shedding the first rays of

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hope. The Special Service section of the group undertook new functions and a theatre, the "Zamboogie", was constructed under the direction of Lieut. Peterson. Here a number of U.S.O. Shows, including the jungle tour of Joe E. Brown aided somewhat in keeping morale from rock-bottom levels.

Early in August a newer version of the "Kittyhawk", the P-40N, arrived for the 7th and 8th Squadrons. These were to replace the old P-40E's and to serve faithfully with the two squadrons until they were outgrown late in 1944. Also in August a new move was in prospect for the 8th Squadron alone. On the 30th of that month that unit moved via air transport to the advance base at Tsili-Tsili, where they made themselves as comfortable as possible in a very restricted area. The 8th Squadron operated from Tsili-Tsili until late in October, when the first contingent moved to the recently captured "perfect airfield site", the Gusap area of the Markham Valley. By November 21 the remainder of the Group had completed the move from Dobodura to Gusap and a campsite was located for the entire group along the banks of the Ramu River.

In the latter part of November the 9th Squadron traded in their P-38's for P-47's and began transition training. The first combat mission flown in this type of aircraft was an escort mission to Wewak. In the encounter the enemy lost eleven fighters while only three of our B-24's were downed. Pilots reported the Wewak airmen as first class Jap material. At the Gusap base the two P-40 squadrons added laurels and proved their worth in the dive-bombing of Shaggy Ridge, giving support to Aussie infantry troops. In recognition of their superior ability the commanding officer of the Australian forces specified these units when requesting air support.

Early in 1944 a change of command was effected when Colonel James C. Selman, who took command of the group in July, 1943, was relieved on 25 January by Lieut. Colonel David A. Campbell. Colonel Campbell was a "pilot's pilot", spending the

hope. The Special Service section of the group undertook new functions and a theatre, the "Zandooie", was constructed under the direction of Louis, later on. There a number of U.S. G. shows, including the jungle team of Joe E. Brown, acted somewhat in keeping with the rock-bottom levels.

Early in August a new version of the "Littsburgh", the L-400, arrived for the 7th and 8th squadrons. These were to replace the old L-400's and to serve faithfully with the two squadrons until they were outgrown late in 1944. Also in August a new move was in progress for the 9th Squadron alone. On the 10th of that month that unit moved via air transport to the advance base at Tullit-Tullit, where they made themselves as comfortable as possible in a very restricted area. The 8th Squadron continued from Tullit-Tullit until late in October, when the first contingent moved to the recently captured "perfect airfield site", the Camp area of the Kaituma Valley. By November 21 the remainder of the Group had completed the move from Boboete to Camp and a complete was located for the entire group along the banks of the Land River.

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Early in 1944 a change of command was effected when Colonel James D. Colman, who took command of the group in July, 1943, was relieved on 27 January by Maj. Colonel David A. Campbell. Colonel Campbell was a "flying ace", spending the

greater part of each day in the air. He was very popular and much admired by both enlisted men and officers, and his loss from a combat mission on 3 June 1944 was lamented by all personnel of the group.

The P-47's remained with the group for a short time only, and in April, 1944, the 9th Squadron again was equipped with P-38's. The return to the twin-engine planes was welcomed by all pilots and crew chiefs who never became reconciled to the "Thunderbolts".

Because there no longer remained any lucrative targets for the 49ers, and because the Allied offensive had taken a giant step with the landings at Hollandia, moving rumors were again afloat in April. These rumors were confirmed and a move to Hollandia, with the ground personnel going via water and staging out of Finschafen and the air echelon flying direct, was completed by 20 May. The trip to Hollandia went wrong from beginning to end, with the advance echelon arriving some ten days after the rear echelon. After remaining aboard a Liberty Ship, the DAVID A. BERRY, in Hollandia harbor for three days, the advance echelon finally got ashore and straggled the twenty miles over the rough mountain roads to the campsite just off Cyclops strip. This group of men suffered some casualties when a fire on Pie Beach caused the explosion of a large ammunition dump.

Hollandia proved to be only a staging area for the 49ers, with Biak Island as the ultimate destination. Very early in June a water echelon was moved to Biak Island, arriving to find the airstrips still in enemy hands. Here on the night of 12 June the ground personnel were the victims of a catastrophic Japanese air attack. Among the fatalities were the Group Executive Officer, temporarily in command of the group, Major Alphas B. White, the Group personnel Officer, the Group S-4 Officer, and a number of other officers and enlisted men. Other personnel were wounded; some like the Chaplain, Captain Stafford, so severely that they had to be evacuated. The Group received a new commanding officer when Colonel Campbell was

at that time of each day in the air. He was very popular and much admired by both enlisted men and officers, and his loss from a combat mission on 7 June 1964 was lamented by all personnel of the group.

The T-47's remained with the group for a short time only, and in April, 1964, the 7th Squadron again was equipped with F-35's. The return to the twin-engine planes was welcomed by all pilots and crew chiefs who never became reconciled to the "four-engine".

Because there no longer remained any lucrative targets for the 49ers, and because the Allied offensive had taken a giant step with the landings at Hollandia, moving targets were again absent in April. These targets were continued and a move to Hollandia, with the ground personnel going via water and staying out of the air. The trip was completed by 20 May. The trip to Hollandia was very rough from beginning to end, with the advance echelon arriving some ten days after the rear echelon. After remaining aboard a Liberty ship, the DAVENPORT, in Hollandia harbor for three days, the advance echelon finally got ashore and attacked the enemy lines over the rough mountain roads to the campsite just off Uyoqwa strip. This group of men suffered some casualties when a fire on the beach caused the explosion of a large ammunition dump.

Hollandia proved to be only a staging area for the 49ers, with Link Island as the ultimate destination. Very early in June a water echelon was moved to Link Island, starting to find the airstrip still in enemy hands. Here on the night of 12 June the ground personnel were the victims of a catastrophic Japanese air attack among the fatalities were the Group Executive Officer, temporarily in command of the group, Major Alpha B. White, the Group Personnel Officer, the Group C-4 Officer, and a number of other officers and enlisted men. Other personnel were wounded; some like the Chaplain, Captain Stafford, so severely that they had to be evacuated. The group received a new commanding officer when Colonel Campbell was

lost during this period of time. Colonel Furlo S. Wagner was assigned, but served for a short time only, being relieved by Lieut. Colonel George A. Walker on 19 July.

The air echelon arrived on Biak in June and until October, the 49ers flew dive-bombing, escort, search and interception missions from this base. Dive-bombing of enemy positions both in Dutch New Guinea and on the northern end of Biak were the principal missions. However, on 10 October, and again on 14 October, the 9th Squadron P-38's escorted B-24's to the Japanese-held oil center of Balikpapan, Borneo, at the time the longest escorted mission in SWPA history. Pilots of the squadron were joined on this flight by Major Richard I. Bong, high scoring ace of the Army Air Forces who had recently returned from a rest tour in the States and was assigned to V Fighter Command as a gunnery instructor. Major Bong aptly demonstrated his gunnery on these missions by adding to his score of 27 enemy planes destroyed in the air with two more enemy fighters. Major Thomas B. McGuire, a former 49er and runner-up on high scoring, who was commanding a squadron of the 475th Fighter Group, also accompanied the 9th Squadron on this mission. The group commander, Lieut. Colonel Walker, led the squadron and there is on file in the Group S-2 Office his excellent account, containing much technical data.

As always with the group when combat dies down, moving rumors were again in the air late in September. Before the move was made, early in October the 7th and 8th Squadrons traded in their old P-40N's for P-38's, making the group an entire "Lightning" outfit. On 13 October the ground echelon left Biak via LST enroute, as rumor would have it, to the Philippines. The convoy first sailed to Hollandia where it was joined by a large number of ships of all discription. Two days out of Hollandia and heading north, all personnel were called together and the overall situation was explained to the troops by Captain Ernest K. Knight, group S-4 officer who was in charge of ground forces. Elements of the Sixth Army would land on Leyte Island on 20 October and the convoy in which the group was sailing would beach on 24 October.

During the night of October 23 gun flashes were seen on the starboard side of the convoy but it wasn't until some time after the landing that those aboard the LST's learned that the Japanese fleet had sortied as far south and east as the southeast tip of Samar Island, in a vain attempt to destroy the Leyte beachhead in conjunction with another fleet element trying to force its way through Surigao Straits to the south of Leyte. On the morning of 24 October, while the convoy approached the beaches at San Jose, just east of Tacloban, the Japanese Air Force appeared in great strength to do its part in the destruction of the beachhead. Engaging in dive-bombing, skip-bombing and suicide tactics, the enemy managed to destroy two small ships but at a high cost to itself. The entire day was one of air alerts, attacking Japanese planes, and gunnery "exercise" by naval ack-ack gunners. These men accounted for a great number of the enemy but later disillusioned the troops aboard the LST's by firing on Naval carrier planes attempting to land on the recently captured Tacloban strip after the carrier, U.S.S. PRINCETON, was sunk southeast of Samar.

The night of 24-25 October was one of feverish activity for the group because the LST on which Headquarters and the 9th Squadron was quartered had shifted off the hastily constructed sandbag ramp, the construction of which was necessitated by beach conditions in the San Jose area. This was corrected the next morning and by noon of 25 October personnel and equipment was moved into the camp area, at the time located on a side road some three miles southeast of Tacloban.

The first two nights on Leyte were nights of sleeplessness for Japanese harassing raids were carried on at all hours, and a tropical storm on the third night rained the group area out. Too, men of the various squadrons were utilized to lay the steel matting on Tacloban strip, putting it in readiness for the arrival of the air echelon. On 27 October Lightnings of the 49th Fighter Group arrived, the first tactical air unit of the Army Air Forces in the Philippines since the Ball of Bataan. The sight of these twin-boon fighters drew cheers from Filipinos and ground

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troops as well as Air Corps personnel, and when the group pilots landed, headed by the group commander, Colonel Walker, Major Richard I. Bong, Major Thomas B. McGuire, and Major Gerald R. Johnson, they were met at the airfield by General MacArthur, General Kenney, and other high ranking officers.

The group score took a sudden turn upward following the arrivals of the various squadrons. From 475 it jumped well over the 500th mark for which the pilots had been shooting, to exceed 600 in time. Lieut. Milden E. Mathre of the 7th Squadron scored the 500th for the group. In the first thirty-one days on Leyte, one hundred Japanese aircraft were definitely destroyed in the air by pilots of this group, aided by attached officers including Major Bong, Major McGuire, and Lieut. Colonel Morrissey, all ex-49ers. Aces were made daily. For this gallant and efficient work the group received the personal commendation of General MacArthur. In a press release he cited the group for its good work and described it as "unsurpassed in the air!"

In mid-December the group moved from its old camp site which had become a mud hole, impassable to vehicles and into which food and mail had to be carried by manpower. The new camp area was one of the best in the Philippines, situated just off the beach road quite close to the barrio of San Jose. The men put their hearts into the work of preparing it for a long stay. Tents were constructed off the ground, all messhalls were screened-in, and semi-permanent buildings were constructed.

A bombshell hit the area on 20 December, just ten days after the last move, when it was announced that the group would take another LST ride. Despite the good food and the recent issue of a case of beer per man, morale hit the bottom. Nonetheless, the LST's were loaded, with Headquarters and the 7th Squadron aboard one and the 8th and 9th aboard the other. All loading arrangements were completed on 26 December and the 49ers were off again with Mindoro as the destination.

The trip from Leyte to Mindoro was a nightmare for those who made it. The

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entire three day period was one mass attack on the convoy by fanatical Japanese pilots, determined to destroy it in the supposed belief that it was destined for Luzon. The greatest blow, and one that shook the spirits of all aboard, was the instantaneous destruction of an ammunition-laden Liberty ship by a "Kamikaze" (suicide) pilot. Escorting aircraft destroyed a number of the Japanese but the majority of the credit must go to the Naval anti-aircraft gunners who did themselves proud in their display of marksmanship, bravery and aggressiveness. Their unconcern in the midst of falling shrapnel and diving enemy aircraft was a steadfast prop for the morale of all personnel aboard. The trip to Mindoro was not without its casualties for, altho the enemy failed to score a direct hit on any LST, one plane struck a glancing blow on the 9th Squadron's LST, fatally injuring one of the group's grounded pilots, while shrapnel injured an enlisted man aboard the other LST.

The group landed on Mindoro to find that there too, there had been excitement. Among the flying officers who had remained overnight there on December 27-28 was Lieut. Colonel Johnson, Group Deputy Commander. He was able to give a first hand account of the shelling of Allied installations there by units of the Japanese fleet which were intent on destroying the Mindoro base. He had also heard the entire attack on the convoy by monitoring the radio, and he assured those who landed that he had had his fingers crossed throughout the three days.

The group's stay on Mindoro was of two months duration only. From this base fighter sweeps were carried to such far-flung targets as Formosa and Jesselton, Borneo. Other missions were of escort nature along the Leyte-Mindoro route, and the escort mission when paratroopers were dropped on Corregidor and Batangas. The Cagayan Valley of northern Luzon was also the target for fighter sweeps by the 49ers. Japanese airborne targets, however, were few and far between, and the score was rising only at a crawl. On the ground the group was located at what was probably the dustiest camp area in the Philippines. Much of this was alleviated by spreading

entire three-day period was and was stated on the copy by Japanese pilots, determined to destroy it in the supposed belief that it was destined for Japan. The greatest blow, and one that shook the spirits of all aboard, was the instantaneous destruction of an ammunition-laden liberty ship by a "kamikaze" (suicide) pilot. Recalling aircraft destroyed a number of the Japanese, but the majority of the credit must go to the Naval anti-aircraft units who did the most in their display of marksmanship, bravery and aggressiveness. Their presence in the midst of falling aircraft and diving enemy aircraft was a constant prop for the morale of all personnel aboard. The trip to Mindoro was not without its casualties for, also, the enemy failed to score a direct hit on any ship, one plane struck a glancing blow on the USS "Spearhead" (LST), fatally injuring one of the group's gunners. While aircraft injured an enlisted man aboard the other LST. The group landed on Mindoro to find that there too, there had been resistance among the living officers who had remained overnight there on December 27-28 and 29. Colonel Johnson, Group Deputy Commander. He was able to give a first-hand account of the shelling of Allied installations there in units of the Japanese fleet which were intent on destroying the line and base. He had also heard the entire attack on the copy by monitoring the radio, and he assumed those who landed that he had had his finger pressed throughout the three days. The group's stay on Mindoro was of two months duration only. From this base lighter sweeps were carried to such far-flung targets as Formosa and Jesselton, Borneo. Other missions were of escort nature along the Iloilo-Mindoro route, and the escort mission when paratroopers were dropped on Corregidor and Babuyan. The Carayan Valley of northern Luzon was also the target for lighter sweeps by the 42nd Japanese airborne targets, however, some for and for defense, and the score was rising only at a crawl. On the ground the group was located at what was probably the busiest camp area in the Philippines. Much of this was alleviated by spreading

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gravel from the Bugsanga River just north of the camp. This river furnished a place to wash vehicles, a wonderful swimming hole, and scenery much like that of the western states---Montana, Wyoming or Colorado. For the first few nights Japanese attacks were carried out against our installations with impunity, with the enemy on a number of occasions actually strafing the area. However, after the arrival of heavy ack-ack ammunition (90 mm), these attacks ceased, tho not before the tale (and true, too) went the rounds of the camp concerning Colonel Johnson who, disgusted with the inability of the ack-ack crews to shoot down the attacking enemy, journeyed to a nearby anti-aircraft position to direct their fire. By the time the 49ers made their next move Mindoro had become a rear area base.

The move from Mindoro to Lingayen, Luzon, was the best the group had ever made. A general exchange of camp areas including tents, cots and vehicles, was made with the 18th Fighter Group, Thirteenth Air Force. While elements of that unit moved into our dust-ridden campsite, the group boarded C-46's and C-47's for the beach camp at Lingayen. There they found tents built off the ground with bamboo frames, the headquarters building located in a shell-shattered school building, and Filipino houseboys for all quarters. On 10 March command of the group was transferred to Lieut. Colonel Johnson by Colonel Walker, who became Chief of Staff, 308th Bombardment Wing. Colonel Johnson was an old 49er from Dobodura days and he was enthusiastically welcomed by all hands. Since the loss of Major McGuire in action, he was runner-up as high score man among the active aces in the Pacific

From 10 March until the present date, 1 July 1945, the group has remained at its beach camp in Lingayen. Missions have been comprised of support to the ground forces of General Kruger's Sixth Army here in Luzon, attacks on shipping in the South China Sea, fighter sweeps to China and over Formosa where the acting group commander, Major George Laven, destroyed the first four-engine "Emily" for the group scoreboard, and dive bombing attacks on targets in northern Luzon and Formosa. For

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his aggressive and highly productive attacks on personnel, railroads and rolling stock, trucks, shipping and installations in Formosa on his "Duckbutt Special" missions, Major Iaven, a fellow-pilot of Colonel Johnson in the Alaska theatre, has earned the nickname, "Sixteenth Air Force." He is often accompanied by other old 49ers who have returned to the group since its arrival on Luzon, among them Major James A. Watkins and Lieut. Colonel Clay Tice, Jr. In its ground support, the group has ably demonstrated its ability to place the Napalm fire bombs, and general demolition bombs where they should go, earning high praise from all ground commanders with whom they have worked.

During its tour of the Pacific the group has earned a long string of "firsts". Its pilots have acquired a large number of decorations, ranging from the Congressional Medal of Honor (Major Bong) down through the list. This group has had on its rosters a long list of Aces and even now has eight. It has been cited by the President twice, and its activities have been described in a number of magazines, including TIME and YANK. Proudest boast of all however, is the score of enemy planes destroyed in the air. At the present that stands at 678 but, for the benefit of those who fear that this group is stalemated, rumors now afloat foretell many more heavy blows for the Japs in a more active area---one in which the group can bring its score to the coveted 1000 mark!

U.S. AIR FORCE

in extensive and highly productive attacks on personnel, railroads and rolling stock, bridges, shipping and installations in Korea on the "Secret Service" mission. Major Jones, a fellow pilot of Colonel Johnson in the Alaska Theatre, has earned the nickname, "Blastmaster of the Forces". He is often accompanied by other old flyers who have returned to the group since the arrival of Jones, among them Major James A. Watkins and Lieut. Colonel Clay Rice, Jr. In the ground support, the group has ably demonstrated its ability to place the heavy fire tanks, and general demolition bombs where they should go, earning high praise from all ground commanders with whom they have worked.

During its tour of the Pacific the group has earned a long string of "Letters". The pilots have acquired a large number of decorations, ranging from the Congressional Medal of Honor (Major Jones) down through the list. This group has had on its roster a long list of Aces and even now has eight. It has been cited by the President twice, and its activities have been described in a number of magazines, including TIME and YOUNG. Promoted most of all however, is the score of enemy planes destroyed in the air. At the present that stands at 678 but, for the benefit of those who fear that this group is unbalanced, rumors now abound that it may score heavy blows for the Japs in a more active area--one in which the group can bring its score to the coveted 1000 mark!